

ADA / WCAG 2.1 Accessibility Audit

Colorado Judicial Branch — Lesson Plans Page

Page	Colorado Judicial Branch — Lesson Plans
URL	https://www.coloradojudicial.gov/community-and-educational-resources/lesson-plans
Standard	Web Content Accessibility Guidelines (WCAG) 2.1, Level AA
Audit Date	May 5, 2026
Method	Code- and structure-level review of public HTML; not a substitute for automated scanning, screen-reader testing, or live keyboard testing.

Summary

The Lesson Plans page meets a number of foundational accessibility expectations, including correct page language, descriptive title, present skip link, properly labeled social-media icons, and good color contrast on body and hero text. Thirteen issues are identified. Three are high severity: the desktop primary navigation is not marked as a landmark, the eleven lesson card titles are styled as headings but implemented as plain `<div>` elements rather than heading tags, and three pairs of video links share identical text but point to different lessons. Six items are medium severity (mostly affecting screen-reader navigation and link clarity), and four are low severity or observational. The most user-impactful fixes are Issues 1 and 2, which together would significantly improve the page's navigability for screen-reader users.

What the Page Does Well

Page language. Correctly set with `<html lang="en">`.

Page title. Descriptive: "Lesson Plans | Colorado Judicial Branch."

Image alternative text. All images have meaningful `alt` text where content is non-decorative.

Social-media icon links. Proper `aria-label` attributes in both header and footer.

Breadcrumb separators. The `|` separators are correctly marked `aria-hidden="true"`.

Skip link. "Skip to main content" is present and functional. (See Issue 6 for a target concern.)

Tab order. No positive `tabindex` values are used, preserving natural DOM tab order.

External-link icons. `aria-hidden="true"` with visible "(Link is external)" text as the accessible label.

Color contrast. Body text (dark navy #0B0925 on white) and hero text (white on dark navy) both pass WCAG AA.

Breadcrumb structure. Uses a proper `<ol>`, correctly implying sequence.

Email link. Properly identified with “(Link sends email)” text.

Issues Found

High Priority

1. Primary Desktop Navigation is Not a Landmark

WCAG 1.3.1, 4.1.2 (Level A) · Fail

The main desktop navigation bar (Courts, Probation, Self-Help and Forms, Programs, Public Access, Jury) is rendered inside a plain `<div>` with no `<nav>` element and no `role="navigation"` attribute. Screen-reader users cannot identify or jump to the primary navigation via landmark navigation. The mobile version (`<nav id="block-mainnavigation-mobile">`) is correctly marked up, but the desktop version — visible to most users — is not.

Fix. Wrap the desktop navigation list in a `<nav aria-label="Main navigation">` element.

2. Lesson Card Titles Are Not Heading Elements

WCAG 1.3.1 (Info and Relationships, Level A) · Fail

All eleven lesson plan card titles (“Rule of Law,” “What’s the Big Idea?,” “History of the Colorado Courts,” and so on) are styled to look like headings (class `heading-4`) but are implemented as plain `<div>` elements, not `<h4>` or any heading tag. Screen-reader users navigating by headings will not be able to jump to individual lesson sections — a major usability loss for keyboard and assistive-technology users.

Fix. Change the card title `<div class="heading-4">` to `<h4>` (or an appropriate heading level consistent with the outline).

3. Duplicate Video Link Text for Different Resources

WCAG 2.4.4, 2.4.6 (Level A / AA) · Fail

Three video link texts appear twice on the page, each pair pointing to the same YouTube URL but serving two different lesson sections: “How the Colorado Courts Work Video” (used for both the Court of Appeals and Supreme Court lessons), “Diving into Appellate Cases Video” (used for both the Court of Appeals and Supreme Court diving lessons), and “What to Expect at Oral Arguments Video” (used for both the COA and Supreme Court oral-argument lessons). Because the link text is identical and destinations are the same, screen-reader users hearing a list of links cannot tell which lesson a video belongs to.

Fix. Disambiguate link text — for example, “How the Colorado Courts Work Video (Court of Appeals)” and “How the Colorado Courts Work Video (Supreme Court)” — or add `aria-label` attributes to each.

Medium Priority

4. Language Switcher Navigation Has No Accessible Name

WCAG 4.1.2 (Name, Role, Value, Level A) · Fail

Both instances of the language switcher (`#block-languageswitcher`, `#block-languageswitcher-2`) are `<div role="navigation">` elements with no `aria-label` or `aria-labelledby`. Screen readers will announce “navigation” with no name, making it indistinguishable from other navigation regions.

Fix. Add `aria-label="Language selection"` to both language-switcher elements.

5. No `aria-current="page"` on Breadcrumb Current Item

WCAG 1.3.1, 4.1.2 (Level A) · Fail

The breadcrumb trail correctly marks separators as `aria-hidden="true"` and omits a link for the current page (“Lesson Plans”), but it does not add `aria-current="page"` to the current page’s `<li>` or its text node. Screen-reader users have no programmatic indicator of where they are in the hierarchy.

Fix. Add `aria-current="page"` to the final breadcrumb item or its containing `<li>`.

6. Skip-Link Target is an Empty Anchor, Not the `<main>` Element

WCAG 2.4.1 (Bypass Blocks, Level A) · Fail

The “Skip to main content” link points to `<a id="main-content" tabindex="-1">` — an empty, invisible anchor inserted before the main content — rather than the `<main>` element itself. While this can technically work in most browsers, it is fragile; some screen-reader and browser combinations will not move focus past the anchor to readable content.

Fix. Move the `id="main-content"` attribute directly to the `<main>` element and add `tabindex="-1"` to it, or remove the intermediate anchor.

7. Heading Hierarchy Skips Levels for Article Sections

WCAG 1.3.1 (Info and Relationships, Level A) · Fail

The page H1 is “Community and Educational Resources.” The article title “Lesson Plans” is an H2, and the three section headings (Background, Full Curriculum, Individual Lesson Plans and Intro Videos) are H3. However, the lesson card titles — which logically belong under “Individual Lesson Plans and Intro Videos” (H3) — are unsemantic `<div>`s rather than H4s (see Issue 2). The heading outline therefore has a large structural gap that breaks logical document structure for assistive-technology users.

Fix. Resolving Issue 2 (changing the lesson card titles to `<h4>`) will resolve this issue.

8. Typo in Link Text — “What’s the Blg Idea? Lesson Plan”

WCAG 2.4.4 (Link Purpose, Level A) · Minor / Fail

The link to this lesson plan contains a capitalization error: “Blg” instead of “Big.” While minor, link text is read literally by screen readers and may cause confusion or mispronunciation.

Fix. Correct to “What’s the Big Idea? Lesson Plan.”

9. “Supreme Court lesson plans:” Link Text Includes a Trailing Colon

WCAG 2.4.4 (Link Purpose, Level A) · Fail

The link text for the Supreme Court full-curriculum download reads “Supreme Court lesson plans:” — with a colon that is part of the surrounding sentence punctuation but is included inside the <a> tag. This is read by screen readers as part of the link name.

Fix. Move the colon outside the <a> tag.

Low Priority / Best Practice

10. “The Colorado Jury System” Link Lacks “Lesson Plan” in Its Text

WCAG Consistency / best practice · Minor

Every other lesson-plan download link explicitly includes “Lesson Plan” in its text (e.g., “Rule of Law Lesson Plan,” “You Be the Judge Lesson Plan”), but the last entry is simply “The Colorado Jury System.” This breaks the consistent naming pattern and gives no indication to users that it is a downloadable lesson plan.

Fix. Rename to “The Colorado Jury System Lesson Plan.”

11. Duplicate Navigation Regions in DOM

WCAG 4.1.1 (Parsing, Level A) · Verify

The secondary navigation and language switcher each appear twice in the DOM — once for desktop and once for mobile. Neither set carries `aria-hidden="true"` to suppress the hidden version from the accessibility tree. When at desktop width, the mobile-nav items remain in the DOM (just CSS-hidden), meaning screen readers may encounter duplicate navigation regions. The mobile nav uses `display: none` via the checkbox toggle, so it is hidden from assistive technology when not active, but this should be verified across breakpoints.

Fix. Ensure off-screen / off-state duplicates are always either `aria-hidden="true"` or genuinely removed from the accessibility tree.

12. “(Link is external)” Text is Visually Rendered, Not Screen-Reader-Only

WCAG 2.4.4 (Link Purpose, Level A) · Observation

External links display “(Link is external)” as visible text appended to the link label (e.g., “Online Payments (Link is external)”). While this is accessible and meets 2.4.4, it is somewhat redundant visually. The convention is typically to use a visually hidden span. This is offered as a design consideration rather than a clear failure.

13. Search Form Label Is Inside a Collapsed <details> Toggle

WCAG Observational · Pass with note

The search input's `<label>Search</label>` is a visible, non-screen-reader-only label. While this is technically correct, the label appears inside the `<details>` search panel which is collapsed by default, so it is not visible to sighted users until the search is opened. Once open, the label and field are visible together, which is fine.

Priority Summary

Issues are listed in the order they are described above. Severity reflects likely barrier to a screen-reader or keyboard-only user navigating the page and reaching individual lesson plans.

#	Issue	WCAG Criterion	Severity
1	Desktop primary navigation missing landmark	1.3.1, 4.1.2	High
2	Lesson card titles not heading elements	1.3.1	High
3	Duplicate video link text for different lessons	2.4.4, 2.4.6	High
4	Language switcher has no accessible name	4.1.2	Medium
5	No aria-current="page" on breadcrumb	1.3.1, 4.1.2	Medium
6	Skip-link target is empty anchor, not <main>	2.4.1	Medium
7	Heading hierarchy gap below H3 section	1.3.1	Medium
8	Typo in link text ("Blg")	2.4.4	Medium
9	Trailing colon inside link tag	2.4.4	Medium
10	Missing "Lesson Plan" in last entry	Consistency	Low
11	Duplicate navigation regions in DOM	4.1.1	Low
12	External-link text rendered visibly, not SR-only	2.4.4	Low
13	Search label inside collapsed <details>	Observational	Low

Recommended Remediation Order

1. Address Issues 1 and 2 first. Together they are the difference between a screen-reader user being able to navigate the page by structure and being forced to read it linearly. Both are simple template changes and resolve Issue 7 as a side effect.
2. Resolve Issue 3 (duplicate video link text). This is a one-time content edit that materially improves link clarity for users hearing links read out of context.
3. Address the medium-priority items (Issues 4 through 9) during the next regular content or template release. Issues 8 and 9 are content fixes that can be made immediately by a content editor.
4. Handle the low-priority items (Issues 10 through 13) as part of routine content review. Issue 11 in particular is worth verifying with a screen reader at multiple breakpoints; the underlying concern may already be mitigated by the existing CSS but should be confirmed.

Scope and Limitations

This audit is based on a structural review of the page's public HTML and is not a substitute for a full accessibility evaluation. A complete audit would additionally include automated testing (axe-core, WAVE,

Lighthouse), manual screen-reader testing across NVDA, JAWS, and VoiceOver, keyboard-only navigation testing, color-contrast measurement on the rendered DOM at the exact rendered pixel sizes, and testing of the embedded YouTube videos for captioning, transcript availability, and player accessibility (none of which were evaluated here). This document does not constitute legal advice regarding compliance with the Americans with Disabilities Act, Colorado House Bill 21-1110, Section 508 of the Rehabilitation Act, or any other statute or regulation. It is a technical conformance review against WCAG 2.1 Level AA criteria intended to support a remediation conversation with the operator of the page.